

Wednesday, 22 July 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON

Overcast

27° 19°

BIRMINGHAM

Overcast

26° 14°

MANCHESTER

Overcast

25° 15°

GLASGOW

Overcast

23° 14°

01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1 **Millions of households across England are facing a hosepipe ban, as Thames Water announces restrictions for 10 million customers.**

The company says three recent heatwaves have contributed to the decision. It means around 15 million people in total across England will now be under hosepipe restrictions.

WEATHER · UK

- 2 **Former MP Ann Widdecombe was reportedly attacked with a hammer 21 times at her Devon home, according to prosecutors.**

Joshua Kerry, 28, is accused of assaulting Ms Widdecombe during a robbery, before stealing her wallet. The details emerged in court as his trial began.

CRIME · UK

- 3 **Parts of the UK are moving closer to official drought status, with eight areas in England now experiencing prolonged dry weather.**

This is the stage immediately preceding a full drought declaration. Water companies are urging customers to conserve water as supplies dwindle.

WEATHER · UK

- 4 **The family of a woman who lay dead in a crashed car for days has confronted the mechanic who allegedly falsified her MOT.**

Police had to intervene as a row erupted between Neil Lewis and the family of Darcy Ross in Cardiff. Ms Ross's vehicle reportedly had serious defects.

CRIME · UK

- 5 **Civil servants based in London are being offered relocation packages to move to a new 'No 10 North' in Manchester.**

The move is part of a government initiative to decentralise operations. It's understood those willing to relocate will receive financial support.

POLITICS · UK

What's coming up

1 **A former World's Strongest Man is set to become a Gladiator, joining the cast of the popular Saturday night show.**

Tom Stoltman, a 6ft 8in athlete from the Highlands, will be part of the fourth series. He's known for his incredible strength and imposing physique.

ON AIR – Would you fancy your chances against a Gladiator who's also a former World's Strongest Man? Who's your favourite Gladiator of all time?

TV · COMING UP

2 **The Grammy Awards are expanding their categories, adding new accolades for Asian Pop and Latin music.**

This move follows huge international success for artists like Bad Bunny and KPop Demon Hunters. It reflects the growing global reach of these genres.

ON AIR – What's your favourite Asian Pop or Latin track that you think deserves a Grammy? Is it good to see the Grammys embracing more global music?

MUSIC · AWARDS

3 **A former Blue Peter presenter has wowed the judges on America's Got Talent with his incredible magic act.**

Joel M made the judges' personal items disappear during his audition on the latest series. He's hoping to follow in the footsteps of other British magicians who've found fame on the show.

ON AIR – Do you remember Joel M from Blue Peter? What's the best magic trick you've ever seen, either live or on TV?

TV · COMING UP

4 **Beatles fans on a tour bus in Liverpool got a huge surprise when they spotted Sir Paul McCartney at traffic lights.**

The bus pulled up alongside his car, much to the delight of the tourists. It's not every day you get to wave to a Beatle!

ON AIR – Imagine spotting a legend like Paul McCartney at the traffic lights! Who would be your dream celebrity to bump into unexpectedly?

MUSIC · UK

5 **Live shopping on social media is booming, with one entrepreneur making a staggering £100,000 in TikTok sales in a single day.**

This new trend sees creators selling products directly through livestreams. It's fast becoming a regular way for many people to shop.

ON AIR – Have you ever bought anything through a live shopping stream on TikTok or another platform? Do you think this is the future of shopping?

SOCIAL MEDIA · TREND

On the schedule

- 1 Tributes are pouring in for football legend Kevin Keegan, who has sadly passed away.**
 Known for his infectious positivity and passion, Keegan was a cherished figure in the game. He leaves behind an incredible legacy as both a player and manager.

ON AIR – What's your favourite Kevin Keegan memory, either as a player or a manager? What do you think his biggest impact on football was?

FOOTBALL · UK
- 2 Reports suggest Manchester United and Arsenal are battling it out to sign French midfielder Manu Kone.**
 The transfer window is hotting up with big names being linked to Premier League clubs. Nico Williams is also rumoured to be heading to the champions.

ON AIR – If you were Manu Kone, which club would you choose, Manchester United or Arsenal? Who do you think your club needs to sign most this summer?

FOOTBALL · UK
- 3 Anthony Joshua is set to return to the boxing ring this Saturday, facing Kristian Prenga in Saudi Arabia.**
 All eyes will be on AJ as he looks to make a statement in his latest fight. It's a highly anticipated return for the former world champion.

ON AIR – Are you excited for Anthony Joshua's return to the ring? Do you think he can get back to the very top of heavyweight boxing?

BOXING · UK
- 4 England all-rounder Jacob Bethell has been ruled out of The Hundred with a knee injury.**
 Bethell, who was due to captain Birmingham Phoenix, will miss the entire tournament. It's a significant blow for his team ahead of the competition.

ON AIR – How big a loss is Jacob Bethell for Birmingham Phoenix? Who do you think will be the standout player in The Hundred this year?

CRICKET · UK
- 5 F1 fans are asking why Lewis Hamilton was penalised but Charles Leclerc wasn't, ahead of the Hungarian Grand Prix.**
 Our F1 correspondent is answering your questions about the latest controversies. It's all building up to another exciting race weekend.

ON AIR – Do you think the F1 stewards are consistent with their penalties? What are your predictions for the Hungarian Grand Prix this weekend?

F1 · GLOBAL

Quick hits

- 1 A new study suggests that 'micro-breaks' involving looking at greenery can significantly boost focus.**
Even a short 40-second glance at a green roof or a nearby plant can help reset your concentration, proving that nature's touch works wonders.
- 2 The delightful trend of 'creative lunchbox art' is bringing smiles to workplaces and schools alike.**
Many are taking inspiration from Japanese bento boxes, transforming everyday sandwiches and snacks into miniature edible masterpieces.
- 3 Experts are noticing a rise in the popularity of 'moonlit walks' as a calming evening ritual.**
People are finding that stepping out under the stars, even for a short stroll, offers a unique sense of peace and perspective before bed.
- 4 A surprising new hobby involves 'identifying cloud formations' and tracking their journey across the sky.**
It's a simple, free pastime that encourages mindfulness and a deeper appreciation for the ever-changing beauty of the weather above us.
- 5 The charming practice of 'leaving small, encouraging notes for strangers' is quietly spreading joy in communities.**
From a kind word on a park bench to a cheerful message tucked into a library book, these tiny gestures are making a big difference.
- 6 Researchers highlight the benefits of 'singing in the shower' for both physical and mental well-being.**
The warm, steamy environment can relax vocal cords, and the private space allows for uninhibited expression, releasing feel-good hormones.
- 7 A growing number of people are discovering the satisfaction of 'restoring old photographs' to their former glory.**
Digital tools make it easier than ever to repair faded or damaged family pictures, preserving precious memories for future generations.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to put together flat-pack furniture, even though it rarely helps?

ANSWER: HUMMING A LITTLE TUNE TO KEEP CALM.

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'odd habit' they absolutely have to do before enjoying a cup of tea. What is it?

ANSWER: STIRRING IT AN EXACT NUMBER OF TIMES.

TALK TOPIC

- You know how sometimes you discover a 'hidden detail' in a place you visit all the time, and it makes you look at it completely differently?

What's a local landmark or a familiar spot where you've recently noticed something new and surprising? Give us a call and tell us about your unexpected discoveries!

- Think about those 'everyday objects' that you've surprisingly had for an incredibly long time, almost like an old friend.

What's an item in your home that you've owned for ages, perhaps longer than anything else, and what's its story? We'd love to hear about your long-lasting companions!

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Animals.** Butterfly taste with their feet, using chemoreceptors to sense host plants and nectar sources.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** Penguins have a special gland that allows them to drink seawater and excrete the salt through their nostrils.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£2 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£2 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- The 'unicorn' is Scotland's national animal, symbolising purity, innocence, and power.
- Bumblebees can fly higher than Mount Everest, if conditions are right, due to their impressive wing strength.
- There's a 'Great Emu War' in Australian history, where soldiers were deployed to combat emus destroying crops.
- The world's quietest room, located at Microsoft's headquarters, is so silent you can hear your own blood flowing.
- The average cloud weighs around 550 tons, roughly the same as 100 elephants.
- In Switzerland, it is illegal to own just one guinea pig, as they are considered social animals that need company.
- Plastic bags were invented in 1965 by a Swedish engineer, Sten Gustaf Thulin, as an alternative to paper bags to save trees.
- The 'Smell of Rain' has a specific name: petrichor, a pleasant earthy scent produced when rain falls on dry soil.

On this day

Day 203 of the year, 162 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Abd-al-Masih; Christian feast day: Anna Wang; Christian feast day: Mary Magdalene; Christian feast day: Markella. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1996 — Skyler Gisondo, American actor
- 1953 — Brian Howe, English singer-songwriter (died 2020)
- 1954 — Lonette McKee, American actress and singer
- 1992 — Selena Gomez, American singer and actress
- 1941 — Estelle Bennett, American singer (died 2009)
- 1943 — Bobby Sherman, American singer-songwriter and actor (died 2025)
- 1947 — Albert Brooks, American actor, comedian, director, and screenwriter
- 1954 — Al Di Meola, American guitarist, songwriter, and producer

THE DAY TODAY

- 1990 — Greg LeMond, an American road racing cyclist, wins his third Tour de France after leading the majority of the race. It was LeMond's second consecutive Tour de France victory.
- 2003 — Iraq War: Members of 101st Airborne of the United States, aided by Special Forces, attack a compound in Iraq, killing Saddam Hussein's sons Uday and Qusay, along with Mustapha Hussein, Qusay's 14-year-old son, and a bodyguard.
- 1943 — World War II: Axis occupation forces violently disperse a massive protest in Athens, killing 22.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1951 — Soviet space dogs: Dezik and Tsygan were launched into a sub-orbital spaceflight from Kapustin Yar and became the first dogs to fly in space and the first to safely return.
- 1943 — World War II: Axis occupation forces violently disperse a massive protest in Athens, killing 22.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1983 — Martial law in Poland is officially revoked.
- 2005 — Jean Charles de Menezes is killed by police as the hunt begins for the London Bombers responsible for the 7 July 2005 London bombings and the 21 July 2005 London bombings.

- 1963 — Crown Colony of Sarawak gains self-governance.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 204 of the year, 161 days left in 2026. Today Birthday of Haile Selassie (Rastafari); Children's Day (Indonesia); Christian feast day: Blessed Basil Hopko; Christian feast day: Bridget of Sweden. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1961 — Martin Gore, English singer-songwriter, guitarist, and producer
- 1965 — Slash, English-American guitarist, songwriter, and producer
- 1942 — Madeline Bell, American singer-songwriter
- 1984 — Celeste Thorson, American actress, producer, and screenwriter
- 1947 — David Essex, English singer-songwriter, and actor
- 1992 — Danny Ings, English footballer
- 1965 — Rob Dickinson, English singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1980 — Sandeep Parikh, American actor, director, producer, and screenwriter

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 1982 — Outside Santa Clarita, California, actor Vic Morrow and two children are killed when a helicopter crashes onto them while shooting a scene from *Twilight Zone: The Movie*.
- 1992 — A Vatican commission, led by Cardinal Joseph Ratzinger, establishes that limiting certain rights of homosexual people and non-married couples is not equivalent to discrimination on grounds of race or gender.
- 1993 — China Northwest Airlines Flight 2119 crashes during takeoff from Yinchuan Xihuayuan Airport in Yinchuan, Ningxia, China, killing 55 people.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 1988 — General Ne Win, effective ruler of Burma since 1962, resigns after pro-democracy protests.
- 1999 — Space Shuttle Columbia launches on STS-93, with Eileen Collins becoming the first female space shuttle commander. The shuttle also carried and deployed the Chandra X-ray Observatory.

Coming to cinemas

JULY 2026	
FRI 24	Heads of State; Untitled DCU
FRI 31	Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026	
FRI 7	Once Upon a Time in a Cinema
FRI 14	Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

JULY 2026	
4–26 JUL	Tour de France (Cycling)
18–26 JUL	World Matchplay Darts, Blackpool
23 JUL – 2 AUG	Commonwealth Games, Glasgow
AUGUST 2026	
W/C 10	Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)
SAT 15	Premier League season begins (2026/27)
22–23	Belgian Grand Prix (F1)